

HANOI VIETNAM

Steaming Hot Pho in Hanoi

Nestled in Vietnam's north, Hanoi harks back to a time before Southeast Asia's recent rapid growth. Its Old Quarter is a labyrinth of ancient, narrow streets, alive with people and a myriad motorcycles, their horns blaring. In the morning, everyone heads for a *pho* stand or restaurant for a bowl of this fresh noodle soup, brimming with crunchy vegetables and tender meat.



Over the centuries Hanoi has been the capital and political center of Vietnam for many different administrations, from conquering 11th-century Chinese dynasties and French colonialists to those of its own republic under Ho Chi Minh. In 2010 it celebrated its 1,000th anniversary and a long history that has included royalty and revolution along with Taoism, Confucianism, communism, and capitalism. Somehow it has managed to both preserve and integrate the past and present in its customs, architecture, and food, and visitors can enjoy the pace of modern Vietnam mingled with colonial Indochina.

The colonial period left its mark on the city, and beautiful examples of the architecture remain today, such as the stunning Grand Opera House and the many tree-lined boulevards. It is also responsible for the origins of the national dish – *pho* – which is said to have taken its name from the French *pot au feu*, a dish built upon the long, slow simmering of bones and aromatics. *Pho* uses the same initial process, but gains from the addition of noodles, spices, and herbs.

Breakfast is the ideal time to experience *pho*, giving you a glimpse into Hanoi life and setting you up for the day's exploring. Choose your restaurant, then stand elbow-to-elbow with locals, fighting to place your order at the busy counter. Vats of stock simmer and the air is fragrant with cinnamon, ginger, and star anise. Rice noodles and raw beef are given a quick hot bath before being placed in a bowl, then the diners follow their own routine, carefully squeezing lime juice and a squirt of hot sauce. A spoonful of sliced chili pepper makes the finished article unique. There is no talking, but this is a noisy affair, the clash of spoon with bowl and the slurping of noodles adding to the cacophony of service.

The bustle of the *pho* restaurant is a warm-up for the day ahead. Hanoi's Old Quarter is humid and busy and you take your life in your hands each time you dare to cross the road. But walking is still the best way to see this part of the city, as each corner brings a surprise, whether it's a street full of ironmongers or a hawker setting up for the day. Where exotic old Vietnam meets the new one head-on, Hanoi is the Asia of your dreams – you're bound to leave wanting more.

North and South

In the middle of the 20th century, during Hanoi's turn to communism, refugees fled from the north, taking their recipes with them, and *pho* appeared in the south. The dish is many-layered in both flavor and texture: the bite of rice noodles is a base for tender meat and the crunch of bean sprouts. But it is in the broth that the complexity of the dish really shows through. Formed from the slow simmering of beef bones, which gives the stock depth, it gains subtle nuances from charred onion, ginger, and the spices of the region – star anise, cinnamon, and cloves. No two recipes are the same. The *pho* of the north, *pho bac*, is a simple affair of rice, meat, and thinner noodles. In the south, *pho nam* is a more elaborate affair that might be filled with beef, chicken, offal, or seafood, and served with a plate of herbs and bean sprouts to add as you like.



Above Fresh *pho* is on sale at most of the roadside cafés in Hanoi



The Best Places to Eat Pho

Pho Gia Truyen inexpensive

Nestled in Hanoi's Old Quarter, a short walk from Hoan Kiem Lake, Pho Gia Truyen (also known as "Pho 49 Bat Dan") is a *pho* restaurant of days gone by. You won't find fancy decor or attentive service, but you will find a version of *pho* that has few rivals. This is one for *pho* bac purists; there is nothing but beef available, although you can choose between *tai* (raw), *chin* (cooked), or *nam* (fatty brisket) by looking at the different cuts that sit tantalizingly behind glass at the service counter. Place your order and then enjoy watching the chef briefly cook the noodles and deftly slice your choice of beef from the display, filling the bowls with a fragrant, cloudy stock. It is then up to you to find a seat among the locals and drink in both the atmosphere and your very fine *pho*.

49 Bat Dan Street, Old Quarter, Hanoi; open 7 AM–11 PM

Also in Hanoi

Northern *pho* doesn't only come with beef: for a fine example of chicken *pho* (*pho ga*) head to **Pho Ga Mai Anh (+84 4 3943 8492; inexpensive)**. Like all the best *pho* restaurants this is a simple open-fronted affair, and its location on Le Van Huu, a short walk from beautiful Hoan Kiem Lake, is perfect for the Old Quarter-based tourist.

Also in Vietnam

In Ho Chi Minh City, **Pho Hua (+84 8 3829 7943; inexpensive)** is on Pasteur Street, just a short taxi ride from the main tourist area. It's been in business for over 40 years and caters to both locals and tourists. Spread over two floors, it's one of the best places for *pho* in the city.

Pho has not escaped the restaurant chain industry, and **Pho 24 (www.pho24.com; moderate)** has many franchises that churn out dependable southern-style renditions of the dish and are popular with the younger Vietnamese. Their air-conditioned outlets are all over Vietnam and offer many different varieties of *pho* along with other dishes such as *com tam* (broken rice with pork) and spring rolls.

Around the World

After the fall of the south in the Vietnam War, many Vietnamese settled outside the country and a large community formed in London. Among the host of Vietnamese restaurants on Kingsland Road in the arty Hoxton district, **Song Que (+44 20 7613 3222; moderate)** easily stands out. It has the widest selection of *pho* in the city, with beef, beef offal, chicken, seafood, and vegetarian options, all bathed in a rich broth.